

Unsung Heroes of Medical Tourism

Language translators are the key to India's medical tourism ecosystem, bridging language barriers and cultural divides between international patients and healthcare providers

BY **KARAN DHAR**

76 | A S ONE STEPS into the international lounge at Fortis Memorial Research Institute (FMRI) in Gurugram, you come across a narrow corridor lined with flags of countries from around the world. There it is easy to forget that just beyond its doors lies the bustle of a busy hospital, where patients and families hurry between appointments, tests and consultations. Inside the lounge, which feels like an oasis of calm, Javed Akhtar, 40, is attending a patient from Iraq.

Akhtar, who learnt Arabic at New Delhi's Jamia Millia Islamia over a decade ago, is one of the first faces many international patients encounter when they arrive in India for treatment. While the hospital helps secure visa invitation letters, Akhtar meets patients at the airport, arranges hotels and transport, accompanies them through medical consultations, and remains on-call for everything—from finding familiar food and SIM cards to navigating the city itself.

"I pick up patients right from the airport and help them with all their needs inside and outside the hospital such as hotels," says Akhtar. "They come to me for their needs, including, hotels, cabs, food, sim card, and sightseeing among others."

Most of the patients come from Iraq, though he also assists visitors from other Arabic-speaking countries such as Algeria and Sudan. On any given day, he juggles several patients, acting not just as an interpreter but as a cultural bridge and trusted guide. Akhtar is now learning Hausa in anticipation of a growing number of Nigerian patients.

Akhtar's colleague, Anwar Bobla, 40, a Russian graduate from the University of Delhi's Faculty of Arts, looks after patients arriving from Turkmenistan, Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Kyrgyzstan, and Tajikistan. On most days, he accompanies four or five patients through outpatient consultations or hospital admissions. "My job is to make sure that patients feel that they are not in an alien place," he says.



Gaurav Gangwani

Language: French
Vaidam, a medical
tourism company